

Linux. KDE (along with GNOME) has played an important role in the penetration of Linux to many Home PCs today. KDE code is available under an open source license, meaning that the KDE source code is available free of charge to anyone who wishes to modify it.



The KDE logo

KDE claims that membership to the group 'The KDE Core Team' is solely merit-based, and the applicant must have distinguished him/herself through outstanding contributions and dedication in the KDE project over a considerable period of time. The 20-member KDE core group decides by means of democratic voting procedures on important issues.

Applications for KDE are developed using the Qt toolkit made by Troll Tech. Qt is a development framework written using C++. It has tools which can be used to develop applications for Unix and Unix-derived platforms. KDE was under attack from Linux purists for having used the Qt toolkit, which at one time was not under a free software license. If a developer wrote an application with the freely available toolkit and decided not to share the source code, he had to pay a royalty to Troll Tech, the makers of Qt. However, if the developer chose to share his source code along with his software, he was not obligated to pay anything to Troll Tech. This semi-open source arrangement was not taken to very kindly. Now, however, Qt is fully open source.

Like most open source companies, KDE, too, is backed by a team of enthusiasts who work for fun in their own chosen way, rather than work for remuneration and adhere to a well-defined rules.